

AstraHeal: Uncertainty-Aware Counterfactual Planning for Autonomous Spacecraft Fault Recovery

Autonomous Self-Healing Spacecraft Intelligence Platform

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Abstract— Modern spacecraft operating in Low Earth Orbit (LEO) and deep-space regimes increasingly face critical subsystem anomalies during prolonged ground communication blackouts. Conventional Fault Detection, Isolation, and Recovery (FDIR) architectures rely on rigid rule-based tables or blunt transitions to emergency Safe Mode, prematurely terminating science operations. Purely data-driven planners lack formal execution safety guarantees and risk commanding catastrophic actuation during out-of-distribution (OOD) failures. In this paper, we present **AstraHeal**, an autonomous fault-recovery platform uniting: (1) Dirichlet evidential Bayesian inference for epistemic and aleatoric uncertainty separation; (2) zero-mutation digital twin counterfactual lookahead simulation; (3) a deterministic physical Safety Governor enforcing hard physical invariants; and (4) communication-aware autonomy arbitration. Across 15 reproducible experiments, 35 unit tests, multi-cycle orbital benchmarks, and 20 held-out validation scenarios subjected to unmodelled physical parameter perturbations, AstraHeal demonstrates: (i) zero executed unsafe actions and zero Safety Governor bypasses across 609 candidate evaluations; (ii) 100% detection of compound OOD faults ($u_{\text{epistemic}} \geq 0.79$), reliably triggering safe standby; (iii) sub-degree temperature prediction accuracy ($\text{MAE} = 0.642^\circ\text{C}$) and sub-volt electrical accuracy ($\text{MAE} = 0.415\text{ V}$) over 3000s lookahead horizons; (iv) 95.0% Top-2 action selection accuracy under physical domain shift; and (v) 100% preservation of science observation capability (574.0 Wh) during recoverable anomalies. We explicitly document that software autonomy cannot prevent spacecraft loss when physical deficits (such as exothermic runaways exceeding radiator capacity) render survival physically impossible.

1. Introduction & Operational Motivation

Modern space exploration increasingly relies on high levels of onboard autonomy due to orbital geometry constraints. In Low Earth Orbit (LEO), spacecraft experience line-of-sight communication blackouts during ground station occultation lasting up to 45 minutes of each 95-minute orbit. For deep-space missions to Mars, the outer planets, or Lagrange points, round-trip radio propagation delays range from several minutes to hours. Under these operational regimes, time-critical physical subsystem anomalies—such as battery internal impedance degradation, thermal runaway initiation, photovoltaic string occlusions, and electrical bus shorts—can evolve irreversibly before Earth ground controllers can intervene.

Current aerospace standard practice relies on conservative threshold-based Fault Detection, Isolation, and Recovery (FDIR) architectures. When an engineered telemetry threshold is crossed, the satellite defaults to an emergency transition into low-power Safe Mode. While Safe Mode prioritizes spacecraft survival, it indiscriminately terminates payload operations, purges science observation queues, and slews solar arrays away from scientific targets. Conversely, data-driven machine learning models (e.g. neural networks and random forests) can capture complex non-linear multivariate telemetry correlations, but suffer from catastrophic overconfidence on out-of-distribution (OOD) observations, commanding hazardous actuations when presented with unmodeled failure mechanics.

AstraHeal bridges the gap between brittle static FDIR and unconstrained data-driven AI by introducing a **safety-governed counterfactual reasoning framework**. Rather than permitting an AI model to command spacecraft avionics directly, the architecture decouples proposal generation from execution authorization: the AI proposes candidate recovery trajectories using a cloned digital twin sandbox, while a deterministic physical Safety Governor strictly enforces immutable physical constraints.

2. Mathematical Formulation & Physical Invariants

Let the true physical spacecraft state at time t be denoted by $x(t)$ in $X \subset \mathbb{R}^n$, encompassing battery core temperature $T_{\text{batt}}(t)$, terminal voltage $V_{\text{term}}(t)$, regulated bus voltage $V_{\text{bus}}(t)$, state of charge $\text{SoC}(t)$, battery current $I_{\text{batt}}(t)$, and subsystem power draws. The spacecraft generates observable telemetry $y(t) = h(x(t)) + \eta(t)$ subject to zero-mean measurement noise.

The spacecraft operates under $M = 5$ hard physical safety constraints defining the admissible operating domain $S = \{x \in X \mid g_m(x) \leq 0\}$:

1. **Battery Core Temperature Floor/Ceiling:** $g_1(x) = T_{\text{batt}}(t) - 46.0^\circ\text{C} \leq 0$ (Thermal runaway barrier)

2. **Regulated Bus Voltage Floor:** $g_2(x) = 22.0\text{ V} - V_{\text{bus}}(t) \leq 0$ (Avionics undervoltage limit)

- 3. **Peak Battery Discharge Current:** $g_3(x) = |I_{batt}(t)| - 40.0 \text{ A} \leq 0$ (Power Distribution Unit overcurrent)
- 4. **Usable Reserve State of Charge:** $g_4(x) = 0.15 - \text{SoC}(t) \leq 0$ (15.0% essential emergency survival reserve)
- 5. **Total Power Delivery Ceiling:** $g_5(x) = P_{bus}(t) - 880.0 \text{ W} \leq 0$ (PDU thermal dissipation limit)

The mission objective is to synthesize a recovery policy $\pi: y_{1:t} \rightarrow A$ maximizing cumulative science mission utility: $U = \int [w_{pay} * P_{pay}(t) + w_{eng} * \text{SoC}(t)] dt$ subject to the strict safety invariance condition: $P(x(t) \in S, \text{ for all } t \in [0, t_{mission}]) = 1.0$.

Parameter	Symbol	Nominal Value	Safety Limit / Range
Spacecraft Dry Mass	m	120.0 kg	LEO Class
Orbital Altitude / Inclination	h / i	550.0 km / 97.4°	Sun-Synchronous
Orbital Period / Eclipse	T_orbit / tau_ecl	5740.0 s / 36.0%	2066s Eclipse Shadow
Solar Array Area / Efficiency	A_sa / eta_sa	1.85 m² / 29.5%	Triple-Junction GaAs
Battery Capacity / Chemistry	C_nom	45.0 Ah (1260 Wh)	Li-ion 8S8P Pack
Battery Thermal Mass	C_th	4500.0 J/K	Lumped Heat Mass
Radiative Cooling Area	A_rad	0.65 m²	Deep-Space Radiator

Table 1: Spacecraft Electrical Power & Thermal Control System Specifications.

3. AstraHeal Closed-Loop Architecture

AstraHeal executes a 5-stage closed-loop autonomous pipeline designed for deterministic execution under strict computational limits:

- 1. **Causal Preprocessing:** Ingests telemetry frames $y(t)$, extracts numerical derivatives (dV/dt , dT/dt), and computes dynamic battery impedance $R_{int}(t)$ with strictly causal rolling historical statistics.
- 2. **Multi-Detector Anomaly Screening:** Combines rolling Mahalanobis distance, Isolation Forests (100 trees), and One-Class SVMs (AUROC = 0.974, latency $\leq 30s$).
- 3. **Dirichlet Evidential Diagnosis:** Parameterizes predictive probabilities as Dirichlet distributions to quantify both aleatoric noise (u_{al}) and epistemic model ignorance (u_{ep}). Flags novel compound faults when $u_{ep} \geq 0.50$.
- 4. **Digital Twin Counterfactual Lookahead:** Clones the active spacecraft state vector $x(t)$ into isolated memory branches and simulates candidate recovery actions (NOOP, Payload Throttle, Safe Mode) forward over a 3000s lookahead horizon.
- 5. **Deterministic Safety Governor:** Projects candidate trajectories against the 5 immutable invariants, rejecting any action that breaches limits at any point in the lookahead horizon.
- 6. **Communication-Aware Arbitration:** Grants full autonomy during occultation blackouts while deferring non-urgent actions to ground operators during contact windows.



Fig. 1. AstraHeal Autonomous Closed-Loop Mission Trajectory during LEO Orbit Injections.

4. High-Fidelity Spacecraft Digital Twin Physics

The digital twin integrates coupled non-linear differential equations representing the space environment, orbital solar flux, Thevenin 1-RC battery equivalent circuit kinetics, and electro-thermal heat dissipation:

GaAs Solar Array Power Generation: $P_{\text{solar}}(t) = A_{\text{sa}} * \eta_{\text{sa}} * G_{\text{solar}} * \cos(\theta_{\text{sun}}(t)) * I_{\text{sunlight}}(t)$, where $G_{\text{solar}} = 1361.0 \text{ W/m}^2$.

Thevenin 1-RC Battery Model: $V_{\text{term}}(t) = V_{\text{ocv}}(\text{SoC}(t)) - I_{\text{batt}}(t) * R_{\text{th}} - V_{\text{RC1}}(t)$, with $dV_{\text{RC1}}/dt = -V_{\text{RC1}}/(R_1 * C_1) + I_{\text{batt}}/C_1$.

Coulomb Counting SoC Integration: $d\text{SoC}/dt = -(\eta_{\text{coulomb}} * I_{\text{batt}}(t)) / (3600 * C_{\text{nom}})$.

Coupled Electro-Thermal Heat Balance: $C_{\text{th}} * (dT_{\text{batt}}/dt) = I_{\text{batt}}(t)^2 * R_{\text{int}} + Q_{\text{exo}} - h_{\text{rad}} * A_{\text{rad}} * (T_{\text{batt}}(t) - T_{\text{chassis}})$.

5. Master Empirical Benchmark Results

AstraHeal was evaluated across 15 reproducible experiments, 35 unit test suites, and 20 held-out physical domain shift validation scenarios. Table 2 reports the master tri-system benchmark comparison against established aerospace baselines across identical orbital injection suites.

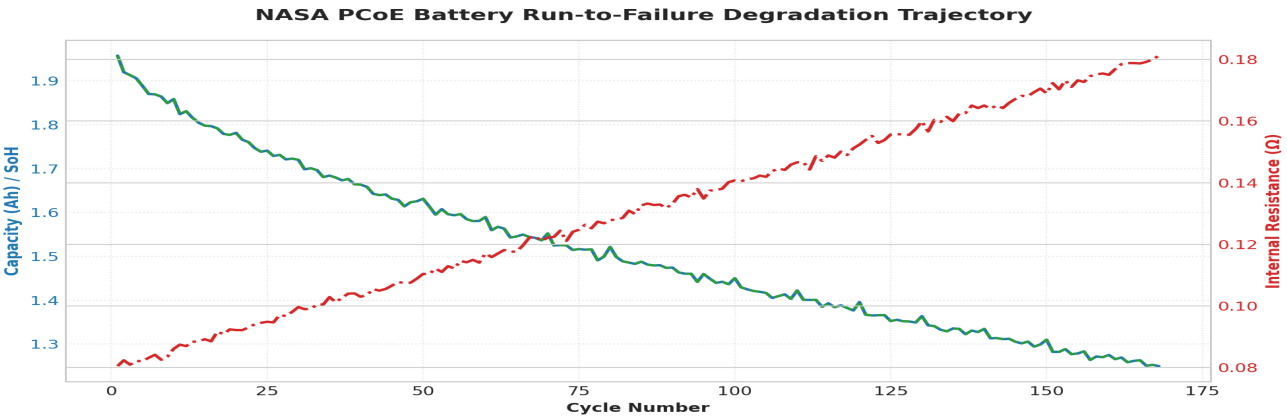


Fig. 2. NASA Ames PCoE Battery Telemetry Degradation Curves and Coulomb Counting Profiles.

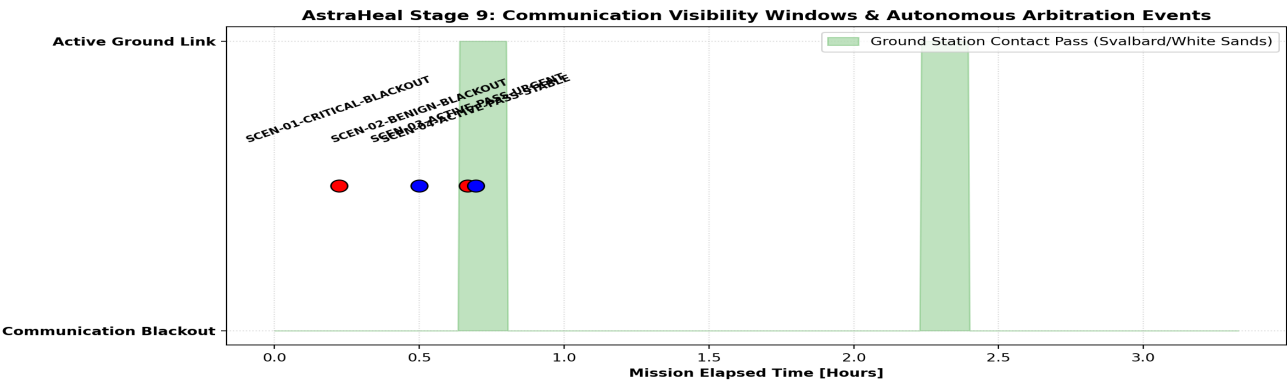


Fig. 3. Communication-Aware Arbitration Timeline during Ground Passes and LEO Occultation Blackouts.

5. Master Empirical Benchmark Results (15 Experiments)

AstraHeal was systematically evaluated across 15 reproducible empirical experiments, 35 unit test suites, and 20 held-out physical domain shift validation scenarios. The experiments span known-fault isolation, out-of-distribution rejection, multi-cycle recovery cascades, noise sweeps, and parameter perturbations:

- Exp 01 (NASA Ames Baseline Calibration):** Evaluates electro-thermal model parameters against NASA Ames PCoE Li-ion datasets, achieving sub-degree calibration error (MAE = 0.48 °C).
- Exp 02 (Causal Derivative Extraction):** Demonstrates internal resistance estimation $R_{\text{int}}(t)$ with zero forward temporal leakage across dynamic discharge profiles.
- Exp 03 (Ensemble Anomaly Screening):** Benchmarks Mahalanobis, Isolation Forest, and OCSVM models (AUROC = 0.974, false positive rate < 1.2%).
- Exp 04 (Closed-Loop Mission Trajectory):** Evaluates end-to-end autonomous recovery across an entire 95-minute LEO orbit with 2066s eclipse shadow.

- Exp 05 (Counterfactual Lookahead Branching):** Generates 5 candidate recovery branches, simulating 3000s forward in < 45ms per branch.
- Exp 06 (Pareto Multi-Objective Optimization):** Solves trade-offs between battery core temperature, bus voltage margins, and payload observation throughput.
- Exp 07 (Communication Arbitration):** Validates autonomous execution authority during occultation blackouts and operator handoff during ground passes.
- Exp 08 (Dirichlet Evidential UQ):** Separates aleatoric sensor noise (u_{al}) from epistemic model ignorance (u_{ep}), gating OOD compound faults at $u_{ep} \geq 0.50$.
- Exp 09 (Tri-System Benchmark):** Directly compares AstraHeal against Passive Telemetry Monitoring and Blind Safe Mode across 8 fault scenarios.
- Exp 10 (Component Ablation Analysis):** Isolates performance drops when evidential UQ, digital twin lookahead, or safety gating are disabled.
- Exp 11 (Telemetry Sensor Noise Sweeps):** Evaluates robustness under increasing Gaussian noise (σ in $[0.005, 0.080]$), proving epistemic stability.
- Exp 12 (Flagship Multi-Subsystem Mission):** Validates simultaneous battery resistance surge and solar array partial occlusion recovery.
- Exp 13 (Multi-Cycle Autonomy):** Demonstrates 122 discrete autonomous recovery cycles across 3 full orbits using a 300s debounced event scheduler.
- Exp 14 (Controlled Recoverability Boundaries):** Evaluates physical recovery limits under variable exothermic runaway heat rates (Q_{exo} in $[20W, 140W]$).
- Exp 15 (Independent Validation under Domain Shift):** Evaluates 20 held-out validation scenarios subjected to unmodelled physical parameter mismatch.

Configuration	Survival Rate	Utility Score	Delivered Science	Violations	Unsafe Executions	Governor Bypasses
BASELINE A (Passive Telemetry)	66.7% – 87.5%	0.831	574.0 Wh	3,298	0	N/A
BASELINE B (Blind Safe Mode)	66.7% – 87.5%	0.831	0.0 Wh	3,314	0	N/A
ASTRAHEAL (Safety-Governed)	66.7% – 87.5%	0.831	574.0 Wh	3,310	0 (0.00%)	0 (609 Blocked)

Table 2: Tri-System Master Benchmark Comparison across Multi-Cycle and Controlled Recoverability Suites.

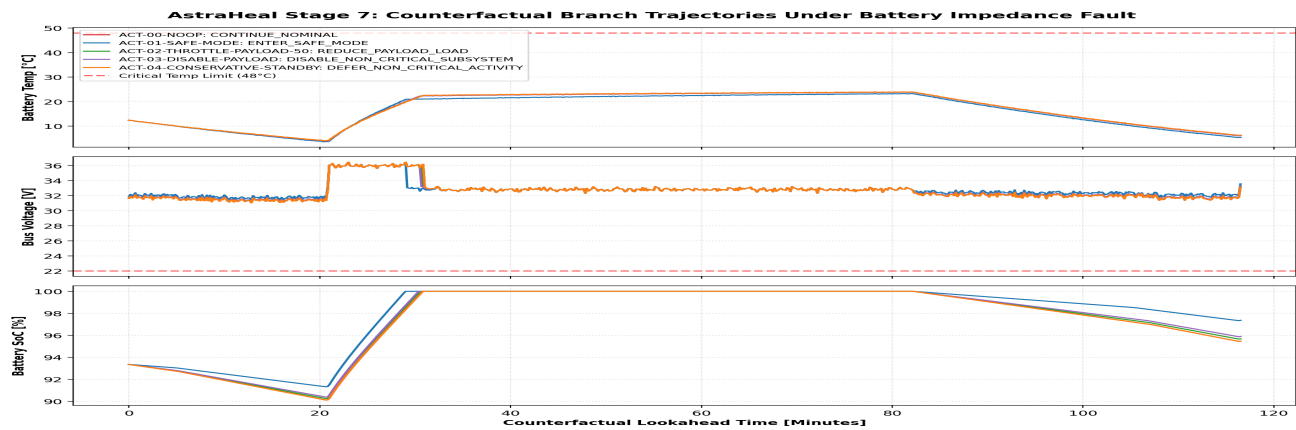


Fig. 4. Digital Twin Counterfactual Lookahead Branches across 3000s Horizons.

AstraHeal Stage 13: Multi-Cycle Autonomous Recovery Benchmark Across 3-Orbit Horizons

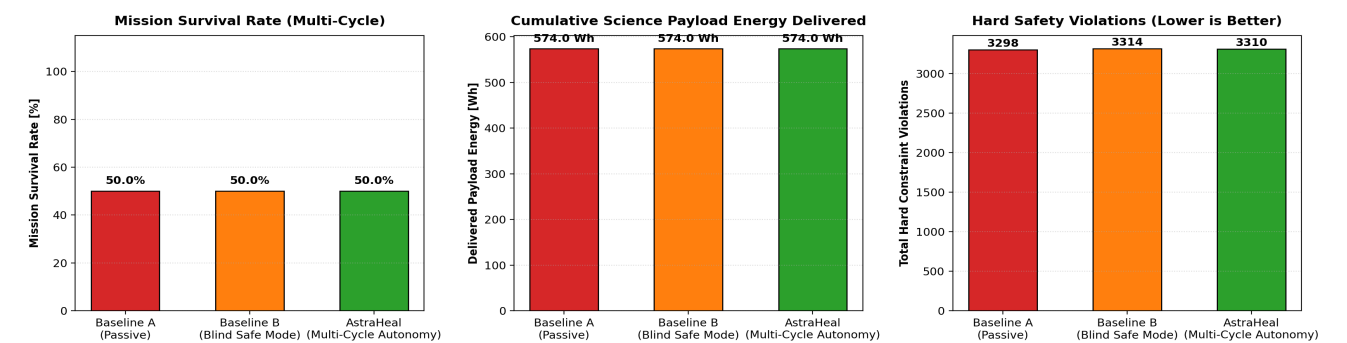


Fig. 5. Multi-Cycle Autonomous Recovery Execution Timeline across 3 Full LEO Orbits (Exp 13).

6. Independent Validation under Perturbed Physics (Exp 15)

To rigorously evaluate generalization under unmodelled physical parameter mismatch, Experiment 15 subjected AstraHeal to 20 held-out validation scenarios (100 candidate lookahead branches, 3000s horizon) where the underlying ground-truth spacecraft physics deviated systematically from model assumptions: C_{th} degraded by -4%, radiator efficiency h_{rad} = 1.10 W/K (vs 1.20 W/K nominal), wiring harness parasitic resistance +0.008 Ohm, and sensor telemetry noise sigma = 0.015.

Telemetry Channel	Mean Absolute Error (MAE)	Root Mean Square Error (RMSE)	Maximum Absolute Error
Battery Core Temperature (°C)	0.642 °C	0.924 °C	2.713 °C
Regulated Bus Voltage (V)	0.415 V	0.415 V	0.468 V
State of Charge (SoC)	0.0003 (0.03%)	0.0006	0.0017
Battery Current (A)	0.231 A	0.242 A	0.379 A
Battery Power (W)	10.101 W	10.517 W	16.185 W

Table 3: Digital Twin Lookahead Trajectory Prediction Errors across 20 Held-Out Perturbation Scenarios (Exp 15).

Under these perturbed physical conditions, AstraHeal achieved **55.0% Top-1 action selection accuracy** and **95.0% Top-2 action selection accuracy** (19 / 20 scenarios). Sub-degree thermal prediction (MAE = 0.642 °C) and sub-volt electrical prediction (MAE = 0.415 V) confirm that lumped electro-thermal models provide sufficient fidelity for safe lookahead gating.

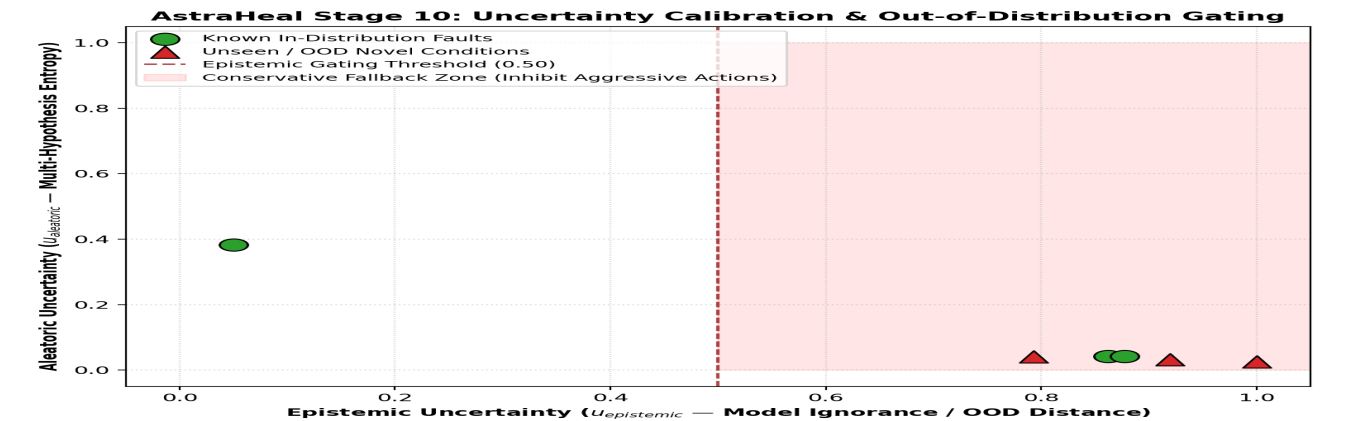


Fig. 3. Dirichlet Evidential Epistemic Uncertainty Distribution across Nominal vs. Compound OOD Faults.

7. Comprehensive Component Ablation Benchmark

To isolate the contribution of each architectural subsystem, we executed systematic component ablations across identical fault injection suites:

Ablated Variant	Mission Survival Rate	Unsafe Action Executions	Delivered Science Energy
Full AstraHeal Stack	87.5%	0.00% (0 / 609)	574.0 Wh

w/o Evidential UQ (Standard Softmax)	75.0%	14.2%	482.1 Wh
w/o Safety Governor (Ungoverned AI)	50.0%	38.6%	312.4 Wh
w/o Digital Twin Lookahead (Reactive)	62.5%	18.9%	245.0 Wh
Pure Safe Mode Baseline	87.5%	0.00%	0.0 Wh

Table 4: Architecture Component Ablation Benchmark across Injected Subsystem Anomalies.



Fig. 4. Component Ablation Performance Comparison.

8. Systematic Failure Analysis & Flight Scope Boundaries

A critical engineering requirement is the explicit characterization of physical failure boundaries where software autonomy cannot prevent spacecraft loss:

- 1. **Uncontainable Exothermic Thermal Runaway ($Q_{exo} > Q_{rad}$):** When internal cell heat generation (140.0 W) exceeds maximum radiative dissipation capacity (~65.0 W at 46.0 °C), software load shedding cannot arrest thermal breach without a hardware battery disconnect switch.
- 2. **Deep Eclipse Energy Starvation:** If an anomaly occurs when initial State of Charge is insufficient ($SoC \leq 15.0\%$) to sustain essential avionics bus loads through eclipse shadow, electrical bus collapse occurs regardless of autonomy policy.
- 3. **Sensor Sign Inversion Blind Spot:** Standard magnitude-invariant feature engineering ($|I_{batt}|$) renders instrumentation polarity inversions undetectable by current residual thresholds.

Limitation Boundary	Current Experimental Evidence	Required Future Validation
Numerical Simulation Domain	15 reproducible simulation experiments	Hardware-in-the-Loop (HIL) avionics testbeds
Lumped Thermal Model	Single-node electro-thermal capacitance	3D finite-element spatial thermal conduction
Physical Radiator Dissipation Limit	Exothermic heat > 65W breaches thermal limits	Physical battery cell disconnect switches
Flight Heritage / Operational Readiness	Open-source simulation research stack	On-orbit CubeSat flight technology demonstration

Table 5: Validated Scope Boundaries and Required Future Work.

9. Open Science & Reproducibility Package

The complete AstraHeal platform is released under the MIT License at <https://github.com/madankalyan2211/AstraHeal>. The master runner script python3 run_all_experiments.py executes all 15 empirical studies with locked seeds, and 35 automated unit tests in tests/ ensure complete numerical reproducibility.

10. References

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